

Surgery explained

Surgery usually involves cutting away some body tissue. It is often used to remove a cancer.

Surgery

Surgery is when a surgeon removes all or part of the cancer. It can be used to treat many types of cancer.

When is surgery used?

Surgery is the main treatment for many cancers. It can be used to diagnose and remove cancer, improve symptoms, and reduce the risk of getting cancer.

Preparing for surgery

Your surgery is planned carefully by your team. They will explain what to expect and how you can plan ahead and prepare for your surgery.

Multidisciplinary team (MDT) for surgery

A team of specialists meet to discuss the best possible treatment for you. This is called a multidisciplinary team (MDT).

Going into hospital for cancer surgery

You usually go into hospital on the day of your operation, or the day before. When you arrive, the nurses will explain what to expect and give you some instructions.

What happens after surgery

Your surgeon or nurse will explain what to expect after surgery. This will include the possible side effects, and how long it may take to recover from your surgery.

Recovering after surgery

How long you stay in hospital depends on the type of surgery you have. If you are staying in hospital for longer than a day, the healthcare team will start planning for your discharge soon after you are admitted to hospital.

How we can help



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.



Cancer information in other formats and languages

We have information about surgery in 16 different languages and other formats, including audiobooks and easy read booklets. You can also request information in any language or format.